Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Amos

Amos 1:1

- words: This is the usual way to introduce a prophetic message (Jeremiah 1:1; see also Haggai 1:12). It emphasizes the form and content of the message.
- sheepherders (Hebrew noqed): This word appears only one other time in the Old Testament, describing the king of Moab as a sheep breeder (2 Kings 3:4). Amos uses a different Hebrew word for his job in Amos 7:14 (boqer, meaning "herdsman"; see Amos Book Introduction, "The Prophet Amos"). Amos was not a professional prophet serving the court or temple.
- Amos received this message through visions, that is, through God's direct revelation (see Isaiah 1:1).
- Amos describes the earthquake during Uzziah's reign (Zechariah 14:5) as an act of God's judgment (Amos 3:14–15; 6:11, 14; 8:8; 9:1, 9).
- Uzziah, also known as Azariah, ruled from 792 to 740 BC. He was the most powerful king of Judah after the kingdom split.
- Jeroboam II, who ruled from 793 to 753 BC, was from Jehu's family line of kings. He took advantage of a time when no strong power controlled the region. During this time, he regained land that the Arameans had taken earlier.

Amos 1:2

- This message speaks about judgment on the day of the Lord (the time when God acts to judge and restore).
- Mount Zion, the place of the temple in Jerusalem, was the natural place for a message from the Lord to come.
- Mount Carmel rises near the Mediterranean Sea and usually has plenty of water, even during dry seasons. If the grass on Mount Carmel dried up, it would be a clear sign of a severe and widespread drought.

Amos 1:3

- For three transgressions of Damascus, even four: This phrase describes ongoing rebellion against the natural order set by God. The Hebrew phrase does not describe an exact number. Instead, it points to a pattern of repeated wrongdoing.
- they threshed: Threshing grain was the process of separating the grain heads from their husks. People did this by pulling wooden sledges with sharp edges over the cut grain (Isaiah 41:15; see Micah 4:13). This image helps explain how harsh and violent the actions of the people of Damascus were.

Amos 1:3–5

Damascus, the capital of Aram, treated the people of Gilead with great cruelty. Gilead was Israel's land east of the Jordan River.

By the time Ahab died in 853 BC, Damascus had taken Ramoth in Gilead (1 Kings 22:3). Around 801 BC, Assyria captured Damascus. After this, the city never again had the power it once did.

Amos 1:3–2.16

This prophecy's eight judgments start with the most obvious enemy, Damascus, and end with the least obvious, Israel itself. This order would have captured Israel's attention as they listened to God's judgment on their enemies. However, Amos eventually revealed God's judgment on Israel, too.

Amos 1:4

- I will send fire upon: In ancient times, invading armies often burned cities after they conquered them (see also Amos 1:7, 10, 12, 14; 2:2, 5). The destruction of Damascus would therefore be an act of God's judgment on the city.
- Hazael ruled as king of Damascus from about 843 to 802 BC. He took the throne by killing the previous king. Ben-hadad, Hazael's son, ruled after him from about 802 to 792 BC.

Amos 1:5

- Aven and Beth-eden were both linked with Aram and Damascus. The name Aven means "evil" or "wickedness." It refers to the valley between the Lebanon and Anti-Lebanon mountains, also known as the plain of Damascus. Beth-eden was a small city-state north of Aram. In other biblical texts, it is simply called Eden (2 Kings 19:12; Ezekiel 27:23).
- The Arameans originally came from Kir (Amos 9:7), probably in southern Babylonia. When Damascus fell, Assyria forced the Arameans to return to Kir (2 Kings 16:9). Just as Egypt symbolized captivity for Israel (see Deuteronomy 28:68), Kir became a symbol of captivity for Aram.

Amos 1:6

The Philistine city of Gaza was located on the seacoast at the southwest edge of Palestine. It served as a gateway for trade between Africa and Asia. Its wrongdoing was engaging in slave trading. Philistia had

attacked Israel or Judah and sold entire villages into slavery to Edom.

Amos 1:7

I will send fire upon: Uzziah defeated Philistia (2 Chronicles 26:6). Later, in 701 BC, an invasion by Assyria nearly erased the Philistines as a distinct people.

Amos 1:8

- The Philistine cities of Ashdod and Ashkelon were located on or near the coast, while Ekron was inland. Gath is not mentioned here because Hazael had conquered it earlier (2 Kings 12:17), followed by Uzziah (2 Chronicles 26:6).
- the remnant of the Philistines: They kept their ethnic identity during the Assyrian period, but this distinction disappeared by the time of the Persians (Zechariah 9:5–7).

Amos 1:9

- Tyre and Sidon were the main seaports of Phoenicia.
- Tyre's crime, like Philistia's (Amos 1:6–8), was selling entire villages of Israelite captives to the Edomites as slaves. This captivity was more painful due to a sense of betrayal (see 2 Samuel 5:11; 1 Kings 5:1, 11; 16:30–31). Tyre was known for its reputation of "anything is for sale." Isaiah described the city as a prostitute selling her goods (Isaiah 23:15–17).

Amos 1:10

fire upon the walls: The main part of Tyre was built on an island, making it almost impossible to capture (see Ezekiel 26:1–28:19).

Amos 1:11

- Edom was another betrayer (see Amos 1:9; Genesis 36; see also Genesis 25:23–30; 27:39–40).
- The word brother refers to Edom's close family relationship with Israel, since both peoples came from Isaac's sons (see Genesis 25:25–30). The word brothers can also describe groups that are bound together by a treaty (see Amos 1:9).

In this passage, Edom's guilt lies in its ongoing hostility toward Israel and Judah. Edom repeatedly attacked Israel's borders and took advantage of times of weakness by raiding and stealing (Jeremiah 49:7–22; Obadiah 1:1–9).

Amos 1:12

When Babylon destroyed the major cities of Teman and Bozrah, Edom lost its ability to continue fighting. Babylon conquered Edom shortly after Judah in 553 BC (see Jeremiah 27; 49:7–22; see also study note on Obadiah 1:18).

Amos 1:13

- Israel saw the people of Ammon as relatives who betrayed them. The Ammonites, like the Moabites (Amos 2:1), were descendants of Lot, Abraham's nephew (Genesis 19:37–38). Ammon was a constant threat to Gilead (see Judges 10:7–9).
- In ancient times, conquering armies often harmed pregnant women (2 Kings 8:12; 15:16; Hosea 13:16). They also raped women and killed children in the towns they captured (Isaiah 13:16, 18; Lamentations 5:11; Hosea 10:14; 13:16; Nahum 3:10; Zechariah 14:2).

Amos 1:14

- Rabbah was the main city of the Ammonites (2 Samuel 12:26).
- The Assyrians defeated Ammon in the 800s BC (Amos 1:13). Later, in the 700s BC, the Babylonians attacked Ammon and forced many of its people to leave the land.

Amos 1:15

Their king: The Hebrew term malkam might refer to the Ammonite god Molech. In ancient times, people believed that when a nation was conquered, its god or gods went into exile with them (see Amos 5:26–27; 1 Samuel 5:1–2; Isaiah 46:1).

Amos 2:1

he burned to lime the bones: In an earlier conflict, the people of Moab captured the king of Edom. Burning a body was viewed as a deep insult. If the king's ashes (literally lime) were then mixed into plaster, the shame would be even greater.

Amos 2:2–3

Kerioth, a major town (Jeremiah 48:20–24), is mentioned on the Moabite Stone as a shrine to Chemosh, the god of Moab. The Moabites may have burned the remains of Edom's king or offered him as a human sacrifice at this site. Because of this act, God would destroy the king of Moab and his officers. This likely happened through an invasion by Sargon II of Assyria around 715 to 713 BC (compare Isaiah 15–16). Josephus, in Antiquities 10.9.7, suggests further destruction in 582 BC (see also Jeremiah 48; Ezekiel 25:8–11; Zephaniah 2:8–11).

Amos 2:4

- reject the Law (Hebrew torah) of the LORD: The pagan nations mentioned earlier committed acts against basic human decency. However, Judah went further; they had God's word but rejected its teachings (see Hosea 4:6; 8:1). God holds people accountable based on the privileges they have received (see Amos 3:2).
- led astray by the lies: After discarding God's true instruction, Judah turned to a substitute found in pagan syncretism (the mixing of different belief systems) and idolatry (see 1 Kings 14:22–24).

Amos 2:4–5

The southern kingdom of Judah was closest to the northern kingdom of Israel in family ties and location. Even so, deep bitterness existed between the two kingdoms.

People in the north viewed the descendants of David in the south as harsh rulers. They believed these kings caused the division between the kingdoms by forcing people to work and by placing heavy taxes on them.

Amos 2:5

The pagan worship practiced in Judah brought the same punishment as the sins of its pagan neighbors. That punishment was fire, a sign of God's judgment, which would destroy Jerusalem (Amos 1:4, 7, 10, 12, 14; 2:2)

This judgment came to pass in 586 BC, when the Babylonians burned Jerusalem after capturing the city (see 2 Kings 25:9; Nehemiah 2:17; 4:2).

Amos 2:6

Honorable people are called the righteous. They lived in right relationship with God and with other people. When this word appears alongside poor, it describes the righteous needy, people who were both faithful and poor.

The law given through Moses urged those who had enough to help those in need by lending freely (Deuteronomy 15:7–11). As a last option, people who could not repay their debts could become bond servants. They would repay what they owed through their work (Leviticus 25:39–43).

In Amos's time, these righteous needy were sold into bond service for a pair of sandals. This phrase is an exaggeration that shows how small the debt was (see Amos 8:6). The sandals may have been given as a pledge for the debt or used as a sign to confirm the agreement (see Ruth 4:7).

Amos 2:6–16

Israel: Amos listed the sins of Israel's neighbors, then revealed his main point: The Israelites would face the same consequences (similar to Nathan's use of prophetic speech to prompt self-judgment, 2 Samuel 12:1–13).

Amos 2:7

- To trample on people means to treat them in a harsh and cruel way (see also Amos 8:4).
- The helpless and oppressed suffered under a system that refused to give them the justice the law required (Exodus 23:6–8).
- When a father and son slept with the same woman, it showed how morally broken the people of Israel had become. The law given through Moses clearly forbade this behavior (Leviticus 18:7–8, 15; 20:11–12).
- profane my holy name: By worshiping fertility gods, Israel and nearby nations practiced "sacred prostitution" (see Hosea 4:10–14). They believed sexual relations with a shrine prostitute would ensure good crops and healthy livestock. This verse suggests these acts were done in the name of the Lord. When performed as religious rituals, these corrupt actions treated God's name as worthless.

Amos 2:8

- The irony is that those who oppressed the poor openly displayed their sins during religious festivals.
- The law of Moses allowed a lender to take a poor man's cloak as security for a debt. However, the cloak had to be returned before nightfall, because nights were cold (Exodus 22:26–27; Deuteronomy 24:12–13). The law also said that a widow's clothing must never be taken as security for a debt (Deuteronomy 24:17).
- fines: The wealthy also imposed unjust fines. They bribed judges and used their power to prevent the poor, who could not defend themselves, from receiving a fair hearing (Amos 5:12).

Amos 2:9

The term Amorites generally refers to the people living in Canaan (see Genesis 15:16; Judges 6:10).

Amos 2:11–12

Besides priests, God gave prophets to share his word and will (Deuteronomy 18:15–19) and holy men called Nazirites, who were dedicated to the Lord by vows that included avoiding fermented drinks (Numbers 6:1–21). Israel showed disrespect for God by telling both the

Nazirites and the prophets to ignore and violate God's calling (see Amos 7:12–13).

Amos 2:14–16

The chapter ends by describing a battle where Israel loses and runs away (see Psalm 33:16–17).

Amos 2:15

The archers stood in the back rows. If they ran away, it meant the front rows had fallen.

Amos 2:16

Amos later refers to that day as the "Day of the LORD" (Amos 5:18). Both expressions mean the time when God will judge Israel (see also Amos 8:3).

Amos 3:1

Amos begins with a reference to God's goodness to Israel when he rescued them from Egypt (see Amos 2:10).

Amos 3:1–2

The first message from the Lord warns Israel that being chosen by God will not protect them from his judgment. They will be held to a higher standard than the surrounding nations.

Amos 3:1–5.17

Amos delivers three prophetic messages to Israel, criticizing their mistaken belief about being God's chosen people. The messages show a progression toward judgment.

Amos 3:2

The word translated as have known suggests a deep, personal understanding that goes beyond just knowing facts. It can mean formal recognition (Exodus 1:8; 5:2), personal experience (Genesis 2:17), or sexual relations (Genesis 4:1). This word often describes God's relationship with Israel (Hosea 5:3) and the ideal relationship Israel should have with God (Hosea 2:20). Because of Israel's special status, God would hold them accountable for all their sins. God holds people accountable based on what they have been given (Luke 12:47–48).

Amos 3:3

Amos's faithful life showed that his message agreed with what God was doing to judge Israel.

Amos 3:3–6

Amos explains his call to prophesy using rhetorical questions that should be answered with "no." However, the metaphorical language has a deeper meaning beyond the questions.

Amos 3:4

Amos delivers messages from God. What he predicts will happen to Israel. God is like a roaring lion, and he has already chosen his target—the people of Israel who are ready for judgment.

Amos 3:5

The trap shows the consequences of Israel's sin. Israel fully deserved the judgment that Amos announced.

Amos 3:6

calamity ... has not the LORD caused it?: God sends both the good and pleasant, as well as the harmful and painful (Isaiah 45:7; Lamentations 3:38; see Deuteronomy 28; Job 2:10).

Amos 3:8

God, like a lion, has roared from Mount Zion (Amos 1:2) and urged Amos to prophesy (see 7:14–16).

Amos 3:9

The prophet now turns to two enemies of Israel: Philistia and Egypt. He names Ashdod, one of the main cities of Philistia. He calls these nations to gather around Samaria, the capital of the kingdom of Israel, and to witness the violence and oppression inside the city.

From the outside, Israel appeared strong. Inside, however, the nation was corrupt and divided by conflict between social groups. Because of this inner weakness, Israel's enemies would be able to take advantage of it (see Amos 3:11).

Amos 3:10

Israel's wealthy people gained their riches by neglecting the poor and by treating the helpless with cruelty (see Amos 2:6–8).

Amos 3:11

The true enemy was not Egypt or Philistia, but Assyria, the only major power in the region at that time.

Amos 3:12

- As the shepherd snatches: The people of both Israel and Judah believed that, because they were chosen,

God would save them and never let them die. The prophet's words are ironic. Their rescue would be like a shepherd arriving too late to save the sheep, only able to pull two legs or a piece of an ear from the lion's mouth.
- just the corner of a bed or the cushion of a couch: This points to how little would remain after the Assyrian attack on Samaria. It suggests that only small pieces of furniture would survive the destruction.

In the same way, only a few people in Samaria would escape. Their rescue would be as incomplete and fragile as the broken remains left behind.

Amos 3:13

- The Lord's message is for all of Israel, also known as the house of Jacob. Jacob was the ancestor of both Israel and Judah.
- The witnesses who are told to listen could be the nations mentioned in Amos 3:9, the people of Samaria, or groups of prophets.
- the God of Hosts: This title (also in Amos 4:13; 5:14–16, 27; 6:8) shows God as the leader of the heavenly armies. This is the true God of the universe, not a local deity (see also Exodus 15:3).

Amos 3:14

the altars of Bethel: Jeroboam I built the shrine at Bethel soon after he became king (1 Kings 12:26–33). It lasted through the Jehu's family line of kings (2 Kings 10:29), from whom Jeroboam II descended. This shrine combined worship of Yahweh (the Lord) with a bull, a pagan symbol. When the altars were destroyed, the Bethel shrine, the king's official sanctuary (Amos 7:13), and the northern kingdom would also fall.

Amos 3:15

Ivory represents the very great wealth that the rich gained in the wrong ways. Archaeologists have found some of these ivory inlays in the ruins of Samaria.

Amos 4:1

you cows of Bashan: Bashan was famous for its fierce, fat bulls (Psalm 22:12; Ezekiel 39:18). Amos uses the feminine form (cows) to describe Israel's wealthy wives, who ignored the poor. They only cared about taking enough wealth from the needy to support their own lifestyles.

Amos 4:1–3

In this message, Amos blames the wives of Samaria for urging their husbands to commit cruel acts to get money for their parties.

Amos 4:2

- has sworn by His holiness: Holiness means God exists outside and independent of creation; his nature is entirely different from what he has created. The oath is similar to Amos 6:8; 8:7.
- hooks: The Assyrians were known for their cruel treatment of war captives (see 2 Chronicles 33:11; compare 2 Kings 19:28). A stela (a stone pillar with an inscription) found in northern Syria shows the Assyrian king Esarhaddon holding cords that go through the lips of two war captives. A recent scholar has suggested that hooks referred to rings inserted into the noses of cattle to control them.

Amos 4:3

The wall of Samaria, which these women relied on for safety, failed to protect them.

Amos 4:4

- Amos sharply criticizes the Israelites' acts of worship because they did not match how they lived.
- Bethel, where Jacob saw his vision of a ladder with angels going up and down (Genesis 28:11–22), was the southern center of the religion started by Jeroboam I (see Amos 3:14; 1 Kings 12:28–29). Gilgal, Israel's campsite after crossing the Jordan River (Joshua 4:19–5:9), had become a popular shrine by the time of Amos and Hosea (Hosea 4:15; 9:15; 12:11).
- sacrifices every morning ... tithes every three days: Israelite males were required to appear before the Lord at the sanctuary three times a year (Exodus 23:14–19; 34:23; Deuteronomy 16:16–17). Tithes were usually paid annually (Deuteronomy 14:22–29), with a special tithe every three years (see Deuteronomy 14:28; 26:12). Amos points out that the Israelites were excessively religious, but they resisted true godliness (Amos 5:15; Hosea 6:6; Micah 6:8; see Luke 11:42).

Amos 4:4–5

The prophet uses sharp words to show how far Israel had turned away from God's ways. Israel practiced many religious acts, but the people did not truly honor God.

Amos 4:5

Leavened bread (that is, sourdough bread made by wild yeast) was eaten every day. Unleavened bread (made without yeast) became a sacred symbol. It reminded Israel of:

- their suffering as slaves in Egypt (Deuteronomy 16:3),

- the Passover (Exodus 12:17–20), and
- their quick departure from that land (Exodus 12:34, 39).

Because of this meaning, unleavened bread became the bread used on the altar (Leviticus 6:17; 7:12). However, bread made with yeast could still be offered with a thanksgiving peace offering (Leviticus 7:13).

Amos 4:6–11

God sent natural disasters to encourage his people to repent, but they did not respond sincerely. Amos ends each disaster account with the phrase: "yet you did not return to Me," declares the LORD.

Amos 4:10

God used plagues to convince Egypt to release Israel (Exodus 7:14–12:30; 9:2–3; Psalm 91:6; Habakkuk 3:5). He warned that if Israel continued to worship pagan gods, he would bring the plagues of Egypt upon them (Deuteronomy 28:27, 60).

Amos 4:11

- Like the plagues on Egypt (Amos 4:10), the plagues on Israel grew stronger and more intense (compare 4:12).
- as I overthrew: The idea that God would treat his own people in the same way he treated Sodom and Gomorrah was very difficult for them to believe, based on what they thought about God (Genesis 19:24–25).

Amos 4:12

This is one of the two important themes in Amos (the second is Amos 5:24). Since Israel did not repent, it must face God's judgment.

Amos 4:13

This verse seems to be a hymn fragment, likely sung by worshipers at Bethel (for other hymn fragments, see Amos 5:8–9; 9:5–6). Israel had been treating God like a baal (a local god with limited power). However, the God they claimed to worship and would face in judgment is all-powerful.

Amos 5:1

lamentation: A lamentation (or lament) is a song or poem of sorrow. It often uses the form of a funeral song, even when it mourns a nation or a people rather than a single death.

The Hebrew word qinah describes a special rhythm used for funeral songs. This rhythm has three beats followed by two beats (3 + 2). Most of the book of Lamentations is written in this qinah rhythm.

This rhythm clearly showed something terrible. Israel was spoken of as if it had already died and was now waiting to be buried.

Amos 5:1–3

The charges against Israel had already been presented (Amos 3:1–2; 4:1–3). Now the time for judgment had come. To make this clear, Amos sang a funeral song for Israel. He spoke as if the nation were already dead.

Amos 5:2

In political terms, virgin means a state that has not been conquered by a foreign power. For example:

- Babylon (Isaiah 47:1)
- Jerusalem (Lamentations 2:13; compare Lamentations 1:1)

Amos 5:3

This verse is a reversal of the promises made in Leviticus 26:8.

Amos 5:4

Seek Me and live implies a condition: To live, Israel must seek the Lord (also in Amos 5:6). Otherwise, the funeral song (Amos 5:1–2) will become Israel's death sentence.

Amos 5:5

- Beersheba was another site (see study note on Amos 4:4) with connections to the patriarchal era (for example, Abraham, Genesis 21:33; 22:19). It had become a shrine.
- Gilgal ... exile: This phrase uses wordplay based on alliteration (the repetition of similar sounds). In Hebrew, the words hagilgal galoh yigleh sound alike. Together, they connect the place name Gilgal with the idea of going into exile.

Amos 5:6

The northern kingdom of Israel, also known as the house of Joseph, was mainly controlled by the tribes of Joseph's sons, Ephraim and Manasseh (see study note on Amos 5:15; see Hosea 5:3, 5).

Amos 5:8–9

- Amos quotes another hymn fragment (see Amos 4:13; 9:5–6). The prophet highlights the difference between the cosmic God and local gods.

- Stars, celestial bodies, and constellations like Pleiades and Orion were seen as gods in ancient times. Amos says this is not true; the Lord created them and placed them in the sky.
- waters: People in ancient times observed a process they did not understand, such as evaporation and condensation (when water turns into vapor and then back into liquid). However, the Lord understands and controls these natural processes, even when they seem mysterious to humans.

Amos 5:10

Amos continues the idea started in Amos 5:7. Wealthy people controlled Israel's courts, which relied on corrupt judges and paid witnesses. They ignored the truth and focused only on what benefited them (Amos 5:12).

Amos 5:11

stone houses: Amos criticizes the wealthy again. Peasants lived in mud brick houses. Cut stone, made by hand, was very costly.

Amos 5:13

Witnesses insisted they saw and heard nothing. Being truthful had become risky (Amos 5:10) and could put the speaker in danger.

Amos 5:14

Amos clarifies his earlier hints (Amos 5:4, 6). Israel must do what is good and right in order to survive.

Amos 5:15

the remnant of Joseph: The phrase the remnant of Joseph comes from the Hebrew text to refer to the northern kingdom. They remained God's people despite their rebellion and idol worship.

Amos 5:16

The farmer ... and the mourners: This expression vividly describes widespread grief. It means that everyone would mourn, from ordinary workers like farmers to people whose job was to mourn at funerals.

Amos 5:16–17

wailing ... mourn ... wailing: People would grieve because of the widespread and certain destruction ahead (Amos 5:1–2).

Amos 5:18

- Amos again challenges the Israelites' mistaken belief about their chosen status (see Amos 3:2).
- The phrase What will the Day of the LORD be for you indicates despair from a great tragedy.
- In the Old Testament, the day of the Lord (see Isaiah 13:6, 9) was when God would intervene to fix what was wrong. God's intervention would mean vindication for the righteous and judgment for the wicked. Israel believed that on that day (see also Amos 8:3, 9, 13; 9:11), God would save them.

However, because the Israelites had been wicked, the day of the Lord would bring darkness, not light. Assyria conquered the northern kingdom in 722 BC (2 Kings 17:7–23), fulfilling this prophecy.

Amos 5:18–6.14

The pronouncements of sorrow in this section develop two main themes:

1. Israel's apostasy (turning away from God) would make the day of the Lord a day of judgment, not salvation; and
2. Judah's spiritual complacency (feeling satisfied and unconcerned about faithfulness to God) would also bring judgment.

Amos 5:21–27

Amos again confronts the religious hypocrisy and spiritual unfaithfulness of the Israelites. They practiced worship outwardly, but their lives did not match faithfulness to God (see Amos 4:4–5; Isaiah 1:10–20).

Amos 5:22

God would not accept the Israelites' offerings. These offerings were attempts to control God through ritual actions, rather than true signs of repentance and faith (see Leviticus 1–6).

Amos 5:24

- This is the second of the major thematic verses in Amos (see Amos 4:12).
- ever-flowing stream: The streams or gullies (wadis) in Israel's dry areas held water only during rainy seasons. However, God desired constant, not just seasonal, justice.

Amos 5:25

- Israel's relationship with God was based on true devotion, which led to obedience (1 Samuel 15:22–23). Sacrifices symbolizing repentance and faith could mend a break caused by sin, but they could not replace living according to God's word.

- Israel wandered for 40 years in the wilderness after the rebellion at Kadesh-barnea (see Numbers 14:32–35).

Amos 5:25–26

The people of Israel claimed that God had to bless them because of the Sinai covenant (the agreement God made with them at Mount Sinai). However, Amos showed that from the very beginning of this covenant, they had continued to follow pagan practices rather than remain faithful to God.

Amos 5:26–27

The names in Amos 5:26 have led to several explanations. However, many interpreters think these names refer to pagan gods whose identities are no longer clear. The "king god" may be Molech, the god worshiped by the Ammonites (see Amos 1:15). The word translated as taken along might mean "you will lift up." In this case, the prophet contrasts Israel or Judah, who carried their idols, with God, who carries his people (see Isaiah 46:1–7).

Amos 6:1

Zion ... Samaria: Including Jerusalem in the message is surprising, but it shows that God does not show favoritism. Anyone who rebels against God will face sorrow. The Hebrew text mentions Zion and Mount Samaria, referring to the strongholds of the two cities. The people of both Judea and Israel were arrogant, thinking the fortresses of Jerusalem and Samaria could not be defeated (see also Amos 4:3). Trusting in physical strength instead of God is a sin.

Amos 6:2

- Calneh and Hamath were Aramean city-states influenced by Israel (see 2 Kings 14:28). Calneh fell to Assyria in 738 BC, and Hamath had to pay tribute soon after. Uzziah had destroyed the wall of Gath (2 Chronicles 26:6), but it also fell to Assyria in 711 BC.
- Are you better: Israel itself fell in 722 BC.

Amos 6:3

day of calamity (literally seat of violence): By this phrase, Amos either meant that:

- Israel's actions may have sped up the Assyrian conquest's violence, or
- the people might have ignored the looming disaster, leading to everyday violence against the poor.

Amos 6:4

People often served meat to honor important guests. Common foods included bread, fruit, vegetables, and dairy products. Wealthy people ate meat regularly, showing their wealth.

Amos 6:5–6

These verses describe people celebrating with excessive drinking and loud behavior.

Amos 6:6

- wine by the bowlful: The word translated as bowl (Hebrew mizraq) is related to a verb meaning "sprinkle" or "splash" (Hebrew zaraq; see Exodus 24:6). The same word describes the basins used for sprinkling blood or water in religious ceremonies (see 2 Kings 12:13; 25:15), adding a sense of sacrilege to this description of their drunkenness.
- over the ruin of Joseph: The Hebrew text reads of Joseph, referring to the northern kingdom of Israel; see study note on Amos 5:6.

Amos 6:8

- The most solemn oath the Lord could make was by his own name (see also Genesis 22:16; Jeremiah 51:14; compare Amos 4:2; Psalm 110:4; Hebrews 6:13–14).
- Jacob's pride (see study note on Amos 8:7): Jacob can mean "cheat" (Genesis 27:36), while Israel means "he struggles with God" (Genesis 32:28). Amos uses Jacob to show the stubborn arrogance that often characterized the people of Israel.

Amos 6:9–10

These verses vividly describe the widespread killing due to military conquest as promised in Amos 6:8.

Amos 6:10

to burn the bodies: Burning the dead (cremation) was rare in the ancient Near East (see study note on Amos 2:1). Because of this, some interpret this phrase to mean "burn a memorial fire" (see Jeremiah 34:5). Others believe it means "dispose of the remains" without cremation. However, the context (the need to dispose of many bodies to prevent decay and disease; Amos 6:9; see 8:3) supports the idea of cremation.

Amos 6:12

- Running horses over cliffs is unwise because unshod horses can damage their hooves on rocks. Obviously, oxen cannot plow the sea either. A slight change in

the Hebrew text asks Can oxen be used to plow them [as in cliffs], which is equally absurd.
- But you have turned: The comparisons highlight Israel's own absurdity in moral matters.
- justice into poison: The people twisted what is just and right, making it toxic and bitter (see also Amos 5:7).

Amos 6:13

Lo-debar and Karnaim were areas that Jeroboam II took back from the Arameans (see 2 Kings 14:25–28). Amos uses wordplay with their names (see Berean Stand Bible textual notes).

Lo-debar sounds like a Hebrew phrase meaning "nothing" or "no word." Karnaim sounds like a word meaning "horns," which were a symbol of strength or power. By using these names, the prophet suggests that what Israel celebrates as strength and success is actually empty and powerless. In the book of Amos, this wordplay supports his message that military victories do not prove God's favor.

Amos 6:14

Lebo-hamath marked the northern border of Solomon's influence (1 Kings 8:65) and the land Jeroboam II recovered. The Dead Sea, also known as the Sea of the Arabah (see footnote on 2 Kings 14:25), marked the southern border of Jeroboam's recovered territory. The irony was clear. The same land that Israel had regained would later be taken over and oppressed by an enemy nation, Assyria.

Amos 7:1

- Locusts (see Amos 4:9) were one of the plagues that affected Egypt (Exodus 10:4). Large swarms of locusts often invaded these lands, especially during droughts.
- king's harvest: The first harvest was given to the king as taxes. The later harvest of the main crop fed the farmer and his family. If locusts ate this crop, starvation would occur.

Amos 7:1–6

The first two visions create a sense of hopeful expectation. God announces judgment, but he withdraws it after the prophet pleads for the people.

Amos 7:1–9.10

This section contains five visions. It is helpful to compare how these visions develop with the judgments listed earlier in Amos 4:6–11.

The judgments listed there include:

- famine,
- drought,
- destruction of crops,
- plagues, and
- widespread destruction.

Amos 7:2

since he is so small?: The kingdom's population was too small to survive such a large loss.

Amos 7:3–6

The Lord changed his decision twice after Amos prayed on behalf of the people.

Amos 7:4

- This fire represents extreme heat and drought.
- the great deep: The Hebrew word refers to the sea, but Amos likely did not think the Mediterranean would vanish. It is probably a poetic reference to large freshwater bodies, like the Kinnereth Sea or Sea of Galilee, which Israel could use for irrigation.

Amos 7:7–9

This vision starts like the previous two (Amos 7:2–3, 4–6), but this time the Lord does not allow intercession. The sudden change in outcome strengthens Amos's message.

Amos 7:8

The Hebrew word for plumb line (Hebrew 'anak) sounds like the word for groaning ('anakhah, see Isaiah 35:10; Lamentations 1:22). This similarity suggests great suffering when God holds Israel accountable.

Amos 7:9

- The high places ... the sanctuaries: Every trace of the unfaithful Israelite religion, from common high places to the royal shrine at Bethel, would be destroyed.
- of Isaac: Isaac represents Israel's ancestors, the founders of the nation.
- the house Jeroboam: Jeroboam II died naturally (2 Kings 14:29), but his son and successor, Zechariah, was murdered after reigning for less than a year (2 Kings 15:8–10; see 2 Kings 10:28–31), which started a period of instability in Israel's government that it never overcame (2 Kings 15:10–31).

Amos 7:10–17

This section shows the corruption of the priesthood, emphasizing that judgment is unavoidable, as highlighted by the surrounding visions.

Amos 7:11

Amaziah misunderstood Amos's words, thinking they threatened Jeroboam's life. Amos was urging the people to repent, not rebel.

Amos 7:12

Flee to the land of Judah ... do your prophesying there: Amaziah thought the people of Judah would value Amos's words and believed Amos wanted payment for preaching.

Amos 7:13

the sanctuary of the king: Amaziah said the Israelites, who were cultured and refined, did not like the prophet. Amaziah was loyal to the king because he wanted to keep his job.

Amos 7:14

- Amos was not a professional prophet or a disciple in training. He had no financial reason to leave his job to prophesy.
- herdsman: The Hebrew word here differs from the one in Amos 1:1 and is not found elsewhere in the Old Testament. It relates to a word for cattle, suggesting Amos may have raised cattle as a breeder or herder (see Amos Book Introduction, "The Prophet Amos").
- The sycamore-fig was gathered for cattle feed.

Amos 7:15

Amos did not seek money. Instead, the Lord's voice (see Amos 1:2; 3:8) inspired Amos to prophesy.

Amos 7:16

against the house of Isaac: Isaac symbolizes all of Israel (see also study note on Amos 7:9; compare Amos 5:6, 15; 6:6).

Amos 7:17

Since Amaziah tried to silence Amos (Amos 7:12–13), the Lord gave Amaziah a harsh prophecy about his life after the Assyrian siege.

Amos 8:1

This vision continues the prophetic sermon that started in Amos 7:1 and was paused for the conversation with Amaziah.

Amos 8:2

the end has come: Amos uses a play on words between summer fruit (Hebrew qayits) and the end has come (Hebrew ba' haqqets). The end had come for God's people, Israel, because they were like ripe fruit, ready to be harvested in judgment.

Amos 8:4–14

This section provides more details on the accusations and decisions mentioned earlier (read with Amos 2:6–6:14).

Amos 8:5

- Work was strictly forbidden on the Sabbath day (Exodus 20:9–10). Amos suggests that shops also closed during pagan new-moon religious festivals.
- Merchants cheated their customers by using small ephahs (containers for measuring grain), so buyers received less than they paid for. They also cheated their suppliers by using heavy shekels (weights of silver) on their scales, so sellers received less payment. God's law clearly forbade these dishonest practices (Leviticus 19:35–36; Deuteronomy 25:13–16; see Proverbs 11:1; 16:11; 20:10, 23).

Amos 8:7

the Pride of Jacob: The same Hebrew phrase in Amos 6:8 refers to Israel's arrogance. Here, it likely names God, the rightful focus of Israel's pride. In other places (Psalm 47:4; Nahum 2:2), this phrase refers to the promised land under a king from David's lineage (compare Jeremiah 13:9; Ezekiel 32:12). If it means the land here, it emphasizes Israel's misguided pride in its national and geographic identity.

Amos 8:9

The day of the Lord would bring a complete reversal of the created order. The world would seem to fall back into chaos, as if creation itself were being undone.

The prophet Jeremiah used similar images when he described the devastation of Judah as the Babylonian armies drew near (Jeremiah 4:23). Other prophets also used this language to describe God's judgment, speaking of the sun, moon, and stars growing dark or disappearing (Isaiah 13:10; 34:4; 50:3; Ezekiel 32:7–8; Joel 2:10, 31; Micah 3:6).

Amos 8:11–14

a famine of hearing the words of the LORD: God sent prophets to Israel to speak directly to them, but Israel told the prophets not to prophesy (Amos 2:11–12). Now they had what they wanted, but the silence was more terrible than God's roar and thunder. God became distant (see Ezekiel 7:26; 20:3; Micah 3:4, 7). The time for speaking was over; the time of judgment had come.

Amos 8:12

from sea to sea: Israel's natural boundaries stretch from sea to sea. The Mediterranean Sea is on the west, and the Dead Sea is on the east. The other borders are simply called the north and the east.

Amos 8:14

- The god of Dan refers to the northern shrine of the golden calf set up by Jeroboam I (see 1 Kings 12:28–29; 2 Kings 10:29).
- the way of Beersheba: Beersheba had apparently become a worship center in the southern kingdom. Archaeologists have discovered the remains of a horned altar in Beersheba's ruins.

Amos 9:1

- I saw the Lord (see Amos 7:1): God stopped explaining how or why he would punish Israel; he was ready to act.
- beside the altar: Judgment must start at the center of worship (compare 1 Peter 4:17). This altar likely refers to the Bethel shrine, but it could also mean the temple in Jerusalem.

Amos 9:2

to Sheol: In the Old Testament, Sheol is a place under the earth where the dead live.

Amos 9:2–4

God is everywhere (compare Psalm 139:7–12). When people trust, believe, and obey God, his presence is a great blessing. However, because Israel rejected God's message, his presence would bring judgment instead of comfort.

Amos 9:3

- Mount Carmel is not the tallest mountain in the area, but it often symbolizes the land's beauty and richness.
- the serpent: In the ancient Near East, people saw the sea as a symbol of chaos, often opposing the national god (compare Psalms 74:14; 89:10; 104:26). The biblical text does not treat the sea monster as a god. Leviathan, also called Rahab, is shown as a creature under the Lord's authority (Psalm 89:9–10). God commands and judges this creature, showing his power over it (Isaiah 27:1).

In this passage, Amos shows that God has power over everything. Even the sea serpent must obey him and serve his purposes.

Amos 9:5–6

Amos uses a third hymn fragment (also Amos 4:13; 5:8–9) to remind Israel that God rules over everything.

Amos 9:7

- the Cushites: Cush (see Genesis 10:6–7) was south of the Second Cataract of the Nile (compare Isaiah 18:1) and was often linked with Egypt, its neighbor to the north.
- Israel's exodus from Egypt is compared to two other ancient migrations: the Philistines from Crete (see also Jeremiah 47:4) and the Arameans from Kir (compare Amos 1:5; 2 Kings 16:9).

Amos 9:8

God would punish Israel by uprooting and scattering them, but he would never destroy them completely. A small group would always remain.

Amos 9:9–10

Even the Lord's most severe judgment is just. God destroys only those who persist in sin. He does not lose a single faithful person. The Lord saves the righteous, who remain faithful to him.

Amos 9:11–12

Amos describes true worship of God as centered on the Jerusalem temple. A descendant of David rules over a united kingdom, including both Israel and Judah (compare Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–5).

Amos 9:11–15

Like many prophets, Amos ends his list of judgments with a message of hope and renewal. Even though Jerusalem and its temple would be destroyed, David's line of kings would be cut off (Psalm 89:38–51), and the people would be taken captive, God would restore a small group of Israelites (see also Isaiah 2:2–4; 4:2; 11:1–5).

Amos 9:12

- Edom (see Amos 1:11) symbolizes the enemies of God and Israel (see Isaiah 34:5–6, 11; 63:1). During the

time of restoration, God's enemies will be subject to his people and to God himself.
- the nations that bear my name: God promised Abraham that he would be a blessing to all the people of the earth (Genesis 12:2–3). God's kingdom will welcome the outcasts and foreigners who were previously excluded (Isaiah 56; see Acts 8:27–39).

Amos 9:13

The mountains will drip with sweet wine: Amos poetically describes a future when people live in harmony with God's creation.

Amos 9:13–15

The future will restore the natural harmony lost in Eden (Genesis 3) and will bring a new era of prosperity.

Amos 9:14–15

God promised not to destroy his people entirely (Amos 9:8). He promised to bring the surviving few back to the land (see Hosea 2:23).